

achieve the exact opposite – playing videogames makes them smarter. Research conducted by University of Rochester shows that they improve decision making skills, perception, and boost creativity. Tests reveal that those who play action-oriented videogames have better cognitive capability than those who don't.

The difference is stark, with gamers being able to make decisions 25 percent faster and with greater accuracy than those who don't play videogames. On an average, gamers can pay attention to six different things at once, as opposed to four for non-gamers.

What's more, playing Real Time Strategy games significantly improves cognitive flexibility according to research done in UK on the subject. "Previous research has demonstrated that action video games, such as Halo, can speed up decision making but the current work finds that real-time strategy games can promote our ability to think on the fly and learn from past mistakes," says Dr Brian Glass from Queen Mary's School of Biological and Chemical Sciences. "Our paper shows that cognitive flexibility, a cornerstone of human intelligence, is not a static trait but can be trained and improved using fun learning tools like gaming."

So do yourself a favour and unwind with a round of Super Meat Boy or StarCraft II the next time your mind goes blank after some serious brainstorming. Science says that not only will you come away a little bit smarter, cognitively faster, and with improved eyesight, but doing so will also get rid of mental fatigue and help you approach work with a fresher perspective. Getting these benefits doesn't necessarily entail staring into a screen. Tabletop Role-Playing Games require a great deal of creativity and imagination and stimulate the brain. Although they aren't quick or convenient means of unwinding, it's lot more satisfying to get invested in epic adventures with your friends and co-workers.

MUSIC: COGNITIVE QUAD DAMAGE

The videogame industry categorically shadows the music industry in sheer scale, but it still doesn't enjoy the universal acceptance as a pastime. Music, on the other hand, is the common denominator that appeals to practically everyone

irrespective of gender, race, or socio-economic background. It's definitely the most accessible form of electronic entertainment medium. Furthermore, its ability to evoke strong emotions makes it an inherently cathartic experience. Listening to your favourite form of music is undoubtedly the easiest and the most effective means of de-stressing yourself.

However, the many virtues of music go beyond mere stress relief. A popular study featured in the journal *Nature* back in the '90s established a link between western classical music and brain development. The study found that listening to classical music tends to improve brain power. The media attention surrounding the study was large enough to warrant a catchy new term capturing the mind-enhancing powers of music. The Mozart effect eventually caught on and prompted parents to play western classical tunes to infants in the hopes of making them smarter.

Does that mean you have to give up your Cannibal Corpse playlist in favour of Beethoven and Mozart? Well, not really. It was later found that the original study wasn't exactly very scientifically sound. It didn't have a large enough sample size and the cognitive improvements lasted only for a short amount of time. More thorough research on this phenomenon confirmed that the positive effect on brain function was only temporary. Furthermore, it was also found that this effect wasn't solely restricted to western classical music.

When the tests were repeated on children, they performed well with Mozart, but the results were even more

impressive with pop music. The upshot is that cognitive improvement manifests simply by the virtue of listening to music that you enjoy. So technically, even Yo Yo Honey Singh fans can potentially become smarter by listening to his music – relatively speaking, of course. Even though the improvement is only temporary, it can still be considered as a power up of sorts. Got stumped by a particularly devious problem? Just listen to your favourite tunes and re-approach it with the cognitive equivalent of Quad Damage.

DE-STRESSING AT AN ENDOCRINAL LEVEL

Stress is often erroneously considered a psychological phenomenon, but it's more psychosomatic in nature. It causes the endocrine system to secrete cortisol – a primary stress hormone responsible for elevating the risk of diabetes, weight gain, suppresses the immune system, damages organs, and increases blood pressure among many more potentially hazardous physiological effects.

Before you worry and elevate your cortisol levels, you might want to know that exercise is the best way to burn away cortisol. Moreover, physical activity also causes the body to secrete endorphins – the body's natural painkiller that also induces a feeling of euphoria. That's right – working out not only kills stress and prevents your body from harm, but it also makes you genuinely and manifestly happy.

That explains why working out for just ten minutes a day puts people at risk of spamming inspirational gym quotes through their Facebook feeds. But jokes aside, nothing can reset your brain and get you in an upbeat mood as effectively as pumping iron in the gym or simply heading out for a quick jog. Doing that will not only get rid of your mental block, but it can potentially unblock clogged arteries as well.

So there you have it – half a dozen ways to de-stress and get your creative juices flowing. Some of these are practical whereas others sound improbable. The easier ones may seem good enough, but the really challenging ones promise greater rewards. You might want to try the ones that seem most approachable, but when the idea is to de-stress it's best not to sweat it and give them all a shot. 



You can rejuvenate your brain by taking a power nap in your favourite chair, and just a 20 minute nap or so